TT AND TRIATHLON BIKES · 5 MIN READ

TT and triathlon bikes: how they differ from road bikes

A time trial or triathlon bike is built for one job: one rider, alone against the clock, holding a low aero position for a long time.

What is different

- **Cockpit**: a flat base bar with brake levers, plus forward extensions with elbow pads. The rider rests on the forearms.
- **Steeper seat tube**: the saddle sits further forward than on a road bike. This keeps the hips open in the low position and saves the legs for the run in a triathlon.
- **Aero tube shapes** and hidden cables.
- **Storage**: triathlon bikes often have built-in boxes and hydration for food and water.

TT bike or triathlon bike

They look alike. A **TT bike** for road time trials has to follow cycling's UCI rules on frame shape and position. A **triathlon bike** does not, so it can carry more built-in storage and use frame shapes the rules would not allow. If a customer races both, check the frame is UCI-legal.

When the customer needs a road bike instead

- **Draft-legal triathlons** require a road bike. Long non-drafting events like Ironman allow triathlon bikes.
- Group rides. The brakes are on the base bar, away from the hands when the rider is on the extensions, so TT bikes are not safe in a bunch.
- A first bike. A TT bike is a second bike for someone who already rides.

A cheaper way to start: clip-on aero bars on a road bike.

Fit decides the result

Most of the air resistance comes from the rider's body, not the bike. A good position is worth more than a more expensive frame. Always sell a TT or triathlon bike with a bike fit.

Why electronic shifting helps here

With Di2 or AXS the rider can shift from the extensions and from the base bar. With mechanical shifting the shifters are only on the extensions.

Remember these

- Base bar plus extensions, steeper seat tube, aero shapes, storage.
- TT bikes follow UCI rules. Triathlon bikes do not have to.
- Draft-legal races and group rides need a road bike.
- The rider is most of the drag, so the bike fit matters most.